GRADE 06
HISTORY

Chapter 1: Defining History

Introduction

By the end of this lesson, you will understand what history means, appreciate why it is worth studying, and learn how to make sense of events that stretch across very long periods of time.

1.1 What is History?

Human beings have been living on this earth for a very long time. During that time,

(a) They have resided in many different parts of the world. (b) They have modified and improved their surroundings to support their way of life. (c) They have formed and maintained relationships with fellow human beings.

The narrative that describes and explains these past human experiences is what we call history. In simple terms, history involves examining and documenting the lives and activities of people who lived before us.

1.2 How to Study History

Since we were not alive thousands of years ago, we have no direct knowledge of what took place in the past. Think about the following examples:

(a) I never had the chance to meet my grandfather's mother. (b) I did not witness the building of my school. (c) I have no firsthand knowledge of the respected elders who once served our village.

All of these situations are part of your own personal history. But how do we come to know about them?

(a) My father told me about my grandfather's mother. (b) A written piece in the school magazine explained how our school was built. (c) Our principal spoke about the village elders during a school assembly.

As you begin learning history, questions like these may naturally arise:

(a) What did the throne of our ancient kings look like? (b) What form of currency was used in this country in earlier times?

★ An ancient throne is currently on display at the Colombo National Museum. ★ Old coins from the past can also be found and viewed at the museum.

Seeing such items with your own eyes helps you understand them better. Simply observing them gives us meaningful knowledge about the past.

We study history through ancient books and written records, as well as through objects and remnants left behind by people of earlier generations. Stories passed down verbally by elders also serve as an important way of discovering the past. Everything that helps us learn about history is referred to by one shared term — **'a source'**.

There are two main categories of sources used to study history:

(a) Literary sources — these include written records from ancient times, such as old manuscripts and folk narratives.

(b) Archaeological sources — these refer to physical remains from the past that still exist today, including ancient objects, building structures, and their ruins.

Examples include human skeletal remains and various objects that were once used by people to obtain or prepare food.

Key sources for studying the history of Sri Lanka:

The Deepawamsa is classified as a literary source, believed to have been composed during the 4th Century AD, though its author remains unidentified. The Mahawamsa is also a literary source, written during the 5th Century AD by Mahanama Thero of Diksanda Senewiya Pirivena, an institution that was connected to Mahawiharaya. The Galvihara situated in Polonnaruwa is an archaeological source, built during the 12th Century AD under the direction of King Parakramabahu I.

Activity 01: In a grid with two columns labelled Literary Sources and Archaeological Sources, list the types of sources that could help you learn about the history of your school.

1.3 Benefits of Learning History

You may find yourself questioning whether there is any real benefit to studying events that have already occurred. However, even though these events are in the past, the insights they offer can help us improve our present circumstances.

Here is a straightforward example. One of the significant challenges we face in the modern world is the environmental damage caused by the widespread use of chemical pesticides and fertilisers.

In earlier times, Sri Lanka was widely recognised as the Granary of the East, owing to the highly effective agricultural practices that were followed. There is no evidence to suggest that the kind of environmental pollution we see today existed back then.

By understanding how people farmed in harmony with nature in the past, we may discover solutions to the environmental problems we face today.

Looking back at history also helps us understand how the things we encounter today came into being. For instance, you may one day wonder how the written scripts you use came to exist in their current form. To understand how scripts evolved, one must study their history. The tradition of writing scripts in Sri Lanka spans approximately 2,250 years. As an example, the Sinhala letter 'ක' went through visible stages of development, recorded at 250 B.C., 250 A.D., 800 A.D., and 1200 A.D., before arriving at the form we recognise today.

By carefully examining both the achievements and the shortcomings of those who came before us, we gain valuable guidance for addressing the challenges of our own time. Moreover, this understanding helps us envision what the future should look like and how we might work toward developing our country further.

Activity 02: Write an essay on the topic "History of Your School."

1.4 How Does History Measure Time?

History encompasses an enormous span of time, so accurately measuring when events occurred is an essential part of studying it. Several methods exist for marking historical time, but the two most widely used are:

(a) Before Christ (B.C.) (b) Anno Domini (A.D.)

Both of these systems are anchored to the year of birth of Jesus Christ. Accordingly:

The period that came before the birth of Jesus Christ is referred to as **'Before Christ (B.C.)'**

The period that followed the birth of Jesus Christ is known as **'Anno Domini (A.D.)'**

To illustrate this with an example — Arahat Mahinda Thero arrived in Sri Lanka 250 years prior to the birth of Jesus Christ. This event is therefore recorded as having taken place in **250 B.C.**

King Mahasen, who is credited with building the Minneriya tank, began his reign over Sri Lanka 274 years after the birth of Jesus Christ. His rule is therefore recorded as beginning in **274 A.D.**

Beyond these two systems, Buddhist years and Saka years are also occasionally used to record historical time. Both of these methods were commonly used in ancient India and Sri Lanka and can still be found referenced in household almanacs today. They continue to be applied in certain historical contexts even now.

The Buddhist year count begins from the day of the passing away (Maha Parinibbana) of the Lord Buddha. While scholars differ on the precise year this occurred, it is generally accepted that the Lord Buddha passed away five hundred and forty four years before the birth of Jesus Christ, which places the event in **544 B.C.**

The Saka year system belongs to the Hindu calendar tradition and began in **78 A.D.** It was introduced by King Gauthamiputhra Sathakarni, who ruled over Western India, to commemorate his victory over the territories of the Saka people.

Muslims use their own chronological system for marking time, particularly in the observance of religious occasions. This system is known as **Hijri years** and began in **622 A.D.**, the year in which the Prophet Mohammad, founder of the Islamic faith, made his journey from Mecca to the city of Madeena.

In addition to these traditional methods, modern laboratory techniques allow historians to calculate dates stretching back hundreds of thousands of years. One such method involves the systematic excavation of the earth, a process known as **archaeological excavation.** When layers of soil are carefully uncovered, objects from different periods of history are revealed. Items from the most ancient times are found in the deepest layers, while more recent remains are closer to the surface.

Significant historical events and their dates according to the A.D. system:

Sri Lanka gained independence in 1948 A.D. King Mahasen began his reign in 274 A.D. King Vasabha's rule commenced in 67 A.D. The birth of Jesus Christ is marked at 1 A.D. The passing away (Maha Parinibbana) of the Lord Buddha is placed at 544 B.C.

The same events expressed in the Buddhist Era system:

King Mahasen's reign began in the 818th year of the Buddhist Era. King Vasabha's reign started in the 611th year of the Buddhist Era. The birth of Jesus Christ corresponds to the 544th year of the Buddhist Era. The passing away (Maha Parinibbana) of the Lord Buddha marks the 1st year of the Buddhist Era.

Activity 03: Express the following events in both A.D. and Buddhist Era formats.

1. Your birthday
2. The current year

Important Points

1. Everything that human beings did in the past is considered part of history.
2. Anything that helps us learn about history is called a source. Sources are grouped into two types — literary sources and archaeological sources.
3. Studying history allows us to better understand the present and helps us plan and prepare for the future.
4. Various systems exist for measuring historical time. Among the most significant are the system based on the birth of Jesus Christ (A.D.) and the system based on the passing away of the Lord Buddha (Buddhist Era).

Chapter 2: Ancient Man

Part I:
2.1. The Environment Where Humanity Originated

2.1.1. Origin of Earth and Life

Our planet is approximately 4,540 million years old. Scientists have proposed various theories about its formation, but the widely accepted view is that Earth emerged from a vast cloud of cosmic dust and gas known as a nebula. When the planet first formed, it was intensely hot. Over time, the surface cooled down, though the Earth's core remains extremely hot to this day — scientists estimate its temperature at around 6,000 degrees Celsius, far beyond the 100 degrees at which water boils. When volcanoes erupt, the superheated material from deep within the Earth flows out as what we call lava.

Life did not appear immediately after Earth formed. The earliest known life form was microscopic — a single-celled organism called Prokaryote Bacteria, which appeared approximately 2,500 million years ago.

Among the earliest multi-celled creatures discovered was one named Opabinia, whose fossilized remains were found in Canada. This creature, estimated to have lived around 542 million years ago, measured between 4 and 7 centimeters in length, had five eyes, and dwelt on the ocean floor.

All early life originated in water. Eventually, living creatures began moving onto land. The first land animals resembled modern millipedes and appeared roughly 420 million years ago — a period geologists call the Silurian Era. Before animals, plants had already spread across the land approximately 542 million years ago, during what is known as the Paleozoic Era. Humans appeared on Earth much later than both plants and animals.

Part II:
2.2. The Evolution of Ancient Man

2.2.1. The Origin of Man

While human beings belong to the animal kingdom, they are remarkable in their ability to create tools and technology, develop language, and express themselves through arts such as music and

dance — capabilities not found in other animals. The path from early ape-like ancestors to modern humans capable of space travel was a long one, shaped by countless challenges.

Humans are believed to have descended from a branch of the ape family. About 2.5 million years ago, during a period of extreme cold known as the Great Ice Age, a group of chimpanzees in Africa began changing in response to the harsh environment. Their facial features and teeth shifted as they adapted to new food sources, and they gradually developed the ability to walk upright on two legs. These changes set the stage for human evolution.

During the Great Ice Age, vast areas of the planet were covered in ice. Vegetation was scarce, fruit was rare, and food was difficult to find. Large animals like mammoths roamed the earth. The Ice Age was not uniformly cold — it alternated between four extended cold periods and four shorter warmer intervals, during which food was more plentiful.

One early ancestor of humans, known as Australopithecus, began distinguishing itself from other apes by picking up and using stones as tools. Evidence suggests that Australopithecus was walking upright as far back as 3.8 million years ago.

Over time, stone tools became more refined. The early human known as Homo Habilis — meaning "capable person" — was among the first to shape stones deliberately by striking them together to create sharp cutting edges. Homo Habilis lived between approximately 2.3 and 1.4 million years ago.

Another key development was the discovery and use of fire. The oldest known evidence of fire use by humans was found in Israel and dates back around 790,000 years. The species credited with first using fire is Homo Erectus, who lived approximately 1.8 million years ago. Fire allowed early humans to cook food, making it easier to digest, and provided warmth during cold periods, contributing to healthier and more comfortable lives.

Gradually, the human body and brain developed further. A species called Homo Neanderthalensis lived around 600,000 years ago. This human constructed shelters from the bones of large animals, cooked vegetables, and was a capable hunter.

Ultimately, the species that gave rise to modern humans is called Homo Sapiens. About 100,000 years ago, Homo Sapiens developed language, music, painting, and dance. All people living on Earth today belong to the Homo Sapiens family.

2.3. The Cultural Evolution of Man

As human beings evolved physically and mentally over approximately 2.5 million years, their way of life changed dramatically. Historians and archaeologists have divided this cultural development into three main stages based on the nature of the stone tools used during each period:

1. The Paleolithic Era (Old Stone Age) 2. The Mesolithic Era (Middle Stone Age) 3. The Neolithic Era (New Stone Age)

2.3.1. Life in the Paleolithic Era

During the Paleolithic Era, people moved constantly from place to place in small groups, typically consisting of a few families totaling between 20 and 30 individuals. They survived by hunting animals and gathering whatever food they could find.

During this period, people began performing burial rituals for deceased members of their group. One practice involved applying red pigment made from a natural mineral called red ochre to the bones of the dead. Since red ochre was not available everywhere, a form of exchange — an early barter system — developed between communities. Toward the end of this era, people began creating artwork, carving figures from stone and bone, and painting images.

2.3.2. Progress in the Mesolithic Era

The Mesolithic Era began at different times in different regions of the world, but is generally estimated to have started between 18,000 and 20,000 years ago. People of this era continued to hunt, but now also used bows and arrows. They began consuming plant-based foods such as nuts, leaves, and yams in addition to meat.

A significant change during this period was that people began staying in one location for longer periods rather than constantly wandering. They built simple shelters from branches and leaves and created paintings on rock surfaces using pigments. The Mesolithic way of life represented a clear advancement over that of the Paleolithic period.

2.3.3. Changes that occurred in the Neolithic Era

The Neolithic Era began approximately 9,000 years ago and brought major transformations in how humans lived. The most significant was the beginning of agriculture. People began growing crops such as wheat, barley, rice, and finger millet. They also began domesticating animals, keeping them for milk, eggs, meat, and fur.

Iron was discovered during this period, allowing for the creation of stronger and more durable tools than stone could provide. The tendency to settle in one place — which had begun in the Mesolithic Era — developed further, and communities began forming permanent villages. Religious practices also emerged during this era, with people worshipping deities connected to farming and animal husbandry.

As agricultural output increased, some people accumulated more wealth than others. This gave rise to social divisions between rich and poor — a development that would eventually lead to the formation of cities and civilizations.

Part III:

2.4. Beginning of Agriculture

Around 12,000 years ago, the Great Ice Age came to an end. The climate gradually warmed, vegetation flourished, and food became more abundant. This era is known as the Holocene.

With the new conditions, people increasingly turned to farming rather than hunting. They learned to identify edible grain varieties and began cultivating them. Different crops were first grown in different parts of the world:

- **Maize** — first cultivated in central Mexico, around 3,000 BC
- **Wheat** — first cultivated in the Mediterranean region, around 9,000 BC
- **Rice (Paddy)** — first cultivated in China, around 7,000 BC

As farming took root, people began settling permanently with their families, building simple homes with clay walls and thatched roofs. Several families living near one another formed what we recognize as the first villages, which appeared around 6,000 BC. The shift from nomadic hunting to settled farming gave people leisure time after harvests, during which artistic pursuits such as painting, sculpture, and music flourished. This agricultural way of life ultimately provided the foundation upon which the world's earliest civilizations would be built.

Human beings also diversified in appearance as populations spread across the globe and adapted to different environments. All modern humans belong to the Homo Sapiens species, but scholars have identified four broad groups based on physical characteristics: Caucasoid, Negroid, Australoid, and Mongoloid. These differences arose from the varying environmental conditions in which people lived over many generations.

The key lesson of this chapter is that humanity's journey — from microscopic life in the oceans to farming communities and civilizations — was a gradual, continuous process shaped by both the environment and human ingenuity.

Chapter 3: Ancient Civilizations of the World

Introduction

Early humans began as wanderers, hunting for food and moving from place to place. As we explored in earlier chapters, people eventually learned to farm and settled into villages. The greatest achievements of humanity came after people began constructing cities and living within them. During this phase, writing systems were invented, trade was conducted using money, and complex societies formed. This period marks what we call civilization. This chapter will help you understand how human beings, despite being animals by nature, rose above all other creatures through the creation of these remarkable societies.

3.1 Origin of Civilizations

In previous chapters, we learned how people gradually adopted village life over thousands of years. Within those villages, individuals who farmed fertile land and raised livestock became prosperous. Others, however, worked on less productive land where water was scarce, making it difficult to grow enough food. These people remained poor. This gap between wealthy and struggling villagers created a social division that would reshape human society.

Over time, the wealthy and their families began separating themselves from ordinary village life. They constructed new settlements with stone buildings instead of clay and wattle structures, with well-laid roads, protective walls and moats, and places of worship. These settlements became known as cities, and those who lived in them were called citizens. Unlike villagers, city dwellers no longer worked the land themselves. Instead, poorer villagers continued farming on land owned by the wealthy, though much of the harvest was taken by the city's elite.

A civilization, in essence, refers to these cities and the societies that developed within them. Cities were larger and more organized than villages. Their inhabitants practiced writing, had governing structures, built religious monuments, and engaged in trade with distant lands. These are the defining features of a civilization.

In different parts of the world and across different time periods, various peoples built their own distinct civilizations. Among the oldest were the Mesopotamian civilization, the Nile River Valley civilization, the Indus Valley civilization, and the Hwang Ho civilization.

3.2 Expansion of Civilizations and its Consequent Benefits to the World

To truly understand what a civilization is, it helps to look closely at several specific examples. This section examines the Mesopotamian, Egyptian, and Indus River Valley civilizations and highlights their most interesting and lasting contributions.

A civilization represents the highest expression of human progress. As you read about how people in these ancient societies created things that continue to benefit us today, you should feel inspired to contribute meaningfully to your own country and society.

Important Points:

- People first established villages, and cities came much later.
- A civilization consists of cities inhabited by large numbers of organized citizens.
- The people of ancient civilizations left behind many gifts that the world still benefits from today.

Part II: Mesopotamian Civilization

Introduction

The Mesopotamian civilization developed in the valleys formed by two great rivers — the Euphrates and the Tigris. The region where these rivers once flowed corresponds to present-day Iraq. The name Mesopotamia itself means "the land between two rivers," which perfectly describes its geography. This civilization flourished between approximately 3,100 and 2,900 BC, making it roughly five thousand years old.

Farming and Agriculture

The farmers of Mesopotamia lived in areas surrounding the main cities and were primarily engaged in cultivating crops and raising livestock. Because rainfall was insufficient in many parts of the region, they developed canal systems to bring water from rivers to their fields. They used animals to pull iron ploughs to prepare the soil for planting, and also used stone hoes as farming tools. Their main crops included grains, fruits, and vegetables, with wheat and barley being the most important grain varieties they cultivated.

Religion and Worship

The people of Mesopotamia regarded natural forces as divine and worshipped them accordingly. Rain, wind, and floods were all seen as expressions of godly power. They believed their purpose in life was to serve and please these nature gods.

Their principal deities included:

- **Anu** — the supreme leader of all gods
- **Enkiki** — the god associated with the Earth

- **Enlili** — the god of wind and agriculture

Every city in Mesopotamia had its own patron deity, and special temples called Ziggurats were constructed to honor them. The priests who served in these temples held positions of great respect and influence within Mesopotamian society.

Trade and Commerce

Mesopotamians were skilled traders who navigated rivers in small vessels, transporting goods including food and drink. The Assyrians, who occupied the northern regions of Mesopotamia, were particularly well known as land traders. They organized caravans — groups of traders who transported merchandise on the backs of donkeys across long overland routes.

Mesopotamian Society

Mesopotamian society was structured into four distinct groups: priests, the upper class, the lower class, and slaves. Priests held the highest authority and performed both religious ceremonies and medical duties. They were identifiable by their shaved heads and cloaks made from sheepskin.

Wealthy men and women of the upper class adorned themselves with gold jewellery. Men typically wore their hair long and kept full beards, while women dressed in garments covering one shoulder and also wore their hair long. Lower class citizens lived modestly but comfortably, worked diligently, and received payment for their labor, though their clothing and accessories were simple rather than lavish.

Scripts

The Mesopotamians are credited with creating one of the earliest writing systems in the world, known as cuneiform script. These writings were made by pressing a sharpened stick into wet clay tablets. The system began as a series of drawn images but gradually evolved into a more structured form of written communication. The clay tablets were used to record a wide variety of information, though trade records were among the most common.

One of the oldest known works of literature is an epic tale written by a Mesopotamian figure named Gilgamesh, recorded in cuneiform. Despite the difficulty of writing on clay, Mesopotamians found creative solutions — they even sent correspondence by enclosing written clay tablets inside clay envelopes. A set of laws compiled by the ruler Hammurabi also survives from this era and is considered the world's oldest known legal document.

The Indus River Valley Civilization

This civilization emerged in the valley of the Indus River, which runs through the northwestern part of the Indian subcontinent. The region it covered now falls within modern-day Afghanistan, Pakistan, and northwestern India. Its peak period of development occurred between 2,600 and 1,990 BC. The two most significant cities of this civilization were Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa.

At its height, the civilization's cities were home to approximately five million people. Residents used metals including copper, bronze, lead, and tin, and constructed their homes from fired clay bricks. The cities featured a remarkably advanced network of water pipes and drainage systems. Urban planning was sophisticated, with well-organized street layouts. The people of the Indus Valley also developed a system of symbols believed to have functioned as a form of writing.

The four principal cities — Mohenjo-Daro, Harappa, Dholavira, and Kalibangan — were all carefully planned. Archaeological excavations have revealed their ruins, along with evidence of an elaborate infrastructure including private wells, gutters, and sewage systems. The existence of well-constructed roads points to an organized system of transportation, and small clay models of wheeled carts suggest that such vehicles were used — or at least familiar enough to serve as children's toys.

A carved stone bust discovered in the Indus Valley is believed to depict a priest. The figure wears a headband across the forehead — a symbol of elevated status — and has half-closed eyes suggesting a meditative state, which further supports the interpretation that the subject held a religious role.

Seal stones belonging to this civilization have also been found, bearing animal engravings and symbols that researchers believe may represent written language, though their meaning has not yet been deciphered.

The Egyptian (Nile River Valley) Civilization

This civilization developed along the lower reaches of the Nile River in Africa around 3,150 BC. Because the region corresponds to modern Egypt, the civilization bears the same name. For much of its history, Egypt was governed by a dynasty of rulers known as Pharaohs. Agriculture formed the backbone of Egyptian society, and the people developed highly effective irrigation methods to support their farming activities.

Egypt's most celebrated contribution to world history is undoubtedly the pyramid. These enormous structures served as burial tombs for Pharaoh kings and their queens. The oldest Egyptian pyramids were built between 2,630 and 2,611 BC. The pyramid complex at Giza, located near the capital Cairo, is recognized as one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World.

Another important achievement was the development of a writing system. Egyptian scholars created a set of symbols derived from images of animals and everyday objects. These are known as Egyptian pictograms or hieroglyphics.

Among notable historical figures from this civilization was Queen Neferneferuaten Nefertiti, who lived between 1,370 and 1,330 BC. She was the wife of Pharaoh Akhenaten and briefly governed Egypt following his death. A sculpture of her bust, believed to have been created during her lifetime, survives to this day and is considered one of the finest examples of ancient Egyptian art.

The Egyptians also developed the practice of mummification — a method of preserving human bodies for extended periods after death. Mummies of both ordinary chieftains and royal figures have been discovered, along with elaborate burial goods such as the famous golden mask placed over the face of King Tutankhamun, who reigned between 1,332 and 1,323 BC.

The civilizations discussed in this chapter each made unique and lasting contributions to human knowledge and culture. From Mesopotamian mathematics to Egyptian architecture to the urban planning of the Indus Valley, the achievements of these ancient peoples continue to shape the world we live in today.

Chapter 4: Settlements in Sri Lanka

Introduction

The first arrival and establishment of people in a country is referred to as settlement. According to historical evidence, people first came to Sri Lanka — an island nation — approximately 125,000 years ago. These early arrivals came from distant lands and are considered the ancestors of the people who live here today. This chapter explores how these early settlers lived and how they gradually developed the country over thousands of years.

Part I
4.1 Early Settlements in Sri Lanka

The very first people to arrive on this island survived primarily through hunting. Alongside hunting, they wandered from one location to another collecting edible plants and other food sources. During rainy seasons they preferred to shelter in caves, while during drier periods they camped in open areas where wildlife was plentiful, since this made hunting considerably easier.

For their daily needs, these early inhabitants relied on tools crafted from stone, which are referred to as stone tools. They also made use of implements fashioned from animal bones and pieces of wood.

Their diet consisted of wild varieties of jackfruit, plantain, and yams. They also hunted animals including deer, giant squirrels, tortoises, hares, porcupines, iguanas, and snails. These communities were spread across many different parts of the island.

Despite their simple lifestyle, these people showed signs of personal expression. They wore jewellery on special occasions — a bead necklace made from a shark's tooth has been recovered from a cave, offering evidence of this practice. However, no clear evidence has survived to tell us how they made or wore clothing.

When members of their community passed away, they buried the bodies within caves. Archaeological discoveries have uncovered the skeletal remains of these burials. The bodies were placed in a curled position, and in some cases red pigment made from a natural mineral called red ochre was applied to the bones. These practices indicate that even the earliest Sri Lankans observed some form of funeral tradition and showed respect for their dead.

Because stone was the primary material used for tools during this period, it is commonly referred to as the Stone Age. Importantly, the people of this era had no concept of ethnic or religious identity. Distinctions such as Sinhalese, Tamil, or Muslim did not exist — such divisions emerged only in much more recent times.

Important Points:

- Human settlement in Sri Lanka began approximately 125,000 years ago.

- The earliest settlers arrived from distant countries and spread across various parts of the island.
- They sustained themselves through hunting and gathering food from nature.
- They practiced jewellery wearing and showed respect for the deceased through burial rituals.
- Tools were made from stone, bone, and wood — giving this period the name Stone Age.
- People of the Stone Age had no religious or racial distinctions among them.

Part II
The Arrival of Prince Vijaya and the Expansion of Settlements

Introduction

The Stone Age in Sri Lanka lasted for more than one hundred thousand years. However, during a period between 4,500 and 5,000 years ago, the people of this island began leading a considerably more advanced way of life. Two key developments marked this progress — the emergence of pottery making and the adoption of iron tools in place of stone ones. When Prince Vijaya and his companions arrived from India around 544 BC, the people of Sri Lanka were already in the midst of this period of advancement. This section examines both the indigenous progress taking place and the significant impact of Vijaya's arrival.

The Earliest Farmers of Sri Lanka

The oldest known farming communities in Sri Lanka lived in the hill country regions, approximately 4,400 years ago — around 2,400 BC. They inhabited the flat elevated areas within mountainous terrain, known as plateaus. Grinding stones used to process grains have been discovered at sites where these communities lived, providing clear evidence that grain formed part of their diet. The specific variety of grain they consumed, however, has not yet been identified.

These early farmers crafted clay pots and urns for storage and daily use. They also discovered how to produce iron by smelting ore — a remarkable technological achievement for their time. Although stone tools remained their primary implements, iron tools were also in use and offered greater strength and efficiency for various tasks.

Their homes were built using clay and wattle construction, with roofs thatched using dried grasses such as Mana or Iluk — materials that farmers in certain parts of Sri Lanka still use for rural shelters today.

These communities also developed burial practices of their own. The deceased were initially buried, then after a period of time the bones were exhumed and cremated. The remaining ash was placed inside a clay pot and deposited within a clay tomb. Over time, these communities migrated from the mountain regions down to the lowland plains, steadily advancing in their way of life. The pottery, iron implements, and dwellings they produced are evidence of a systematic and developing technology.

The Arrival of Prince Vijaya

Historical records indicate that a prince named Vijaya, accompanied by a group of seven hundred followers, sailed from India and landed in Sri Lanka around 544 BC. This account is recorded in detail in the Mahawamsa, one of the most important historical chronicles for understanding the history of Sri Lanka. The location where Vijaya and his companions came ashore is called Thambapanni, situated along the western coastline of the island.

According to traditional accounts, three groups of people — the Yakka, Naga, and Deva tribes — were already living in Sri Lanka when Prince Vijaya arrived. A woman named Kuweni, belonging to the Yakka tribe, captured Vijaya's companions and concealed them. When Vijaya went searching for his people, he encountered Kuweni, who is said to have been spinning cotton at the time. Realizing she was from the Yakka community, Vijaya confronted her and secured the release of his followers. He later married Kuweni, and together they had two children — a son named Jeewahattha and a daughter named Disala.

The Yakka people had two cities of their own, called Sirisawatthu and Lankapura. During a celebration in Sirisawatthu, Kuweni assisted Prince Vijaya in overpowering the Yakka people, enabling him to establish himself as the ruler of Sri Lanka.

Following the defeat of the Yakkas, Vijaya ended his relationship with Kuweni and subsequently married a princess from the Pandya kingdom in India.

The people who came with Prince Vijaya gradually settled in various locations across the country. According to the Mahawamsa, villages were established in the area near the Malwathu Oya river. One of Vijaya's ministers, Upatissa, founded a settlement called Upatissa Gama, while another minister named Anuradha established what became known as Anuradhagama.

The Mahawamsa identifies Prince Vijaya and his seven hundred companions as belonging to the Aryan community. Following their arrival, many customs and social practices from Indian society of that era gradually took root in Sri Lanka as well.

Important Points:

- The people of the Stone Age in Sri Lanka eventually transitioned into an agricultural way of life.
- Iron was discovered approximately 4,000 years ago, alongside the development of pottery and clay craftsmanship.
- Burial tombs were constructed and funeral ceremonies were observed by these early communities.
- According to the Mahawamsa, Sri Lanka's recorded settlement history includes the arrival of Prince Vijaya and his seven hundred companions approximately 2,500 years ago.

This chapter illustrates how Sri Lanka's early history was shaped by two parallel stories — the gradual development of indigenous communities who learned farming, craftsmanship, and iron production, and the arrival of Prince Vijaya whose settlement expanded the island's population and introduced new cultural practices. Together, these threads form the foundation of Sri Lankan civilization.

Chapter 5: Our Brave Kings

Introduction

For any nation to truly prosper, it requires rulers who are both virtuous and wise. For approximately two thousand years, Sri Lanka stood as an equal among the great nations of the world. Sailors who traversed the Indian Ocean knew this small island by many different names — Sihaladeepa, Silediba, Ceylan, Serendib, and Taprobane among them. The island earned its fame through its natural beauty and the valuable goods it exported through trade. It was widely recognized as an independent land governed by courageous and intelligent rulers who dedicated themselves to the wellbeing of their people. This chapter introduces you to some of those remarkable kings.

5.1 King Pandukabhaya

Prince Pandukabhaya was born to Prince Deeghagamini and Princess Chithra. His early education was provided by a Brahman teacher named Pandula. Historical accounts describe a childhood marked by significant hardship — there were those who actively opposed his right to the throne and made attempts to prevent him from ever becoming king. Despite these obstacles, the young prince navigated each challenge with intelligence and determination. Upon reaching adulthood, he married a princess named Swarnapali and assumed the throne.

King Pandukabhaya chose Anuradhapura as his seat of power. At that time the area was known simply as Anuradhagama and was relatively undeveloped. The king set about transforming it into a proper city worthy of the name Anuradhapura.

His first step was to define the boundaries of the new city. He then had a protective moat constructed around the designated area. Four entrance gates were built facing each of the main directions, and a network of roads was laid to connect them. The interior of the city was beautified with gardens and decorative ponds.

The king also demonstrated a forward-thinking approach to urban management. Recognizing that a functioning city required proper waste disposal, he organized dedicated teams of workers for this purpose. He assigned five hundred workers to general city cleaning duties, twenty two to the maintenance of lavatories, one hundred and fifty to handling the transportation of deceased persons, and another one hundred and fifty to the upkeep and security of burial grounds.

A hospital was established to serve the health needs of the city's residents. The king also constructed temples and places of worship for followers of various faiths, demonstrating a commitment to religious harmony. Near the western entrance of the city, he built shrines for blacksmiths who worshipped a deity called Kammaradeva, as well as places of worship for the indigenous Wedda community and various other religious groups.

King Pandukabhaya was also responsible for constructing the first tank ever built adjacent to a city in Sri Lanka. Originally named Abhaya Wewa, this reservoir is known today as Basawakkulama tank and can still be found in Anuradhapura.

After ruling for seventy years and dedicating himself entirely to the service of his people, King Pandukabhaya left behind a legacy of perseverance and public service. His life — shaped by childhood adversity yet defined by determined leadership — offers a valuable example for all citizens.

Important Points:

- Prince Pandukabhaya endured many hardships during his early years.
- He overcame every obstacle and became king, with Princess Swarnapali as his queen.
- He transformed the settlement of Anuradhagama into the city of Anuradhapura.
- He made Anuradhapura into a well organized and attractive city.
- King Pandukabhaya was the first ruler to construct a reservoir near a city, named Abhaya Wewa.

5.2 King Devanampiyatissa

King Devanampiyatissa was the son of King Mutaseewa. Historical records do not mention his mother. He had nine brothers and two sisters and was the second born among his siblings. Before ascending to the throne, he was simply known as Prince Tissa, and he became king following the death of King Mutaseewa.

During this period, the great Emperor Ashoka ruled over India. After Prince Tissa came to power, he dispatched a group of emissaries to the Indian court, led by a nobleman named Prince Aritta. On their return, Emperor Ashoka sent back royal gifts and ceremonial items required for a formal coronation. King Tissa's coronation was subsequently conducted according to the instructions provided by Ashoka. The honorific title "Devanampiya," meaning "beloved of the gods," which was used by Emperor Ashoka himself, was later attached to King Tissa's name — giving him the title by which history remembers him.

The most significant event of King Devanampiyatissa's reign was the arrival of Buddhism in Sri Lanka. Arahath Mahinda, the son of Emperor Ashoka, led a group of Buddhist monks to the island 237 years after the passing of the Lord Buddha. The king received them with the deepest respect and honor.

Before committing to supporting Buddhism, Arahath Mahinda tested the king's intelligence with a series of questions about a mango tree nearby. The king answered each question with remarkable clarity and logic, convincing Arahath Mahinda that he was both wise and capable of upholding the teachings of the Buddha.

King Devanampiyatissa showed tremendous generosity toward Arahath Mahinda and his companions — Ittiya, Uttiya, Sambala, Baddhasala, novice monk Sumana Samanera, and a

layman called Bhanduka. He had the Mahamewuna garden prepared and within it constructed a temple called Tissarama, which he offered to Arahath Mahinda.

5.2.1. Thuparamaya

One of the most enduring contributions of King Devanampiyatissa was the construction of Thuparamaya — the first Buddhist stupa built in Sri Lanka. Having no prior knowledge of what a stupa should look like, the king consulted Arahath Mahinda, who described a shape resembling a heap of paddy grains. The stupa was accordingly built in that form, known as Dhanyakara. Through reconstructions carried out in later eras, it eventually took on its current bell shape, known as Ghantakara. Three rows of stone pillars surrounding the stupa are the remnants of a circular protective structure called a Vatadageya, which was later built around it by King Vasabha. The right collar bone of the Lord Buddha is enshrined within Thuparamaya.

In addition to Thuparamaya, the king constructed a Dana Sala named Lahabath Ge for providing meals to Buddhist monks, along with several pirivenas for monastic education. This entire complex was named Maha Vihara and offered to the Maha Sangha.

5.2.2. The Arrival of Sri Maha Bodhi

During King Devanampiyatissa's rule, a sacred sapling from the Bodhi tree under which the Buddha attained enlightenment was brought to Sri Lanka. The venerable nun Sangamitta Theri transported it by ship from India, arriving at the harbour of Dambakolapatuna, which was located in the Jaffna region. The king personally went to receive both the Sri Maha Bodhi and Sangamitta Theri, escorting them ceremoniously to Anuradhapura. Eighteen groups of craftspeople accompanied Sangamitta Theri on the voyage. The sacred tree was formally planted in the Maha Mewuna garden, and the king erected a building called Maha Bogeya as a further offering to the Maha Sangha.

The king also had sixty eight caves in the Mihintale mountain range cleaned and offered them to Arahath Mahinda and the monks who had been ordained. These came to be known as Ata Seta Len — the sixty eight caves.

Another notable achievement was the formal demarcation of Anuradhapura city, carried out under the guidance of Arahath Mahinda. Historical accounts state that the boundary was marked using a plough drawn by two tuskers named Maha Paduma and Kunja.

King Devanampiyatissa holds the distinction of being the first Sri Lankan monarch to embrace Buddhism. The order of nuns in Sri Lanka began with the ordination of Queen Anula, wife of the king's brother, while the order of monks was established with the ordination of Prince Aritta, a relative of the king.

Important Points:

- The title Devanampiya attached to this king's name means "beloved of the gods."
- He underwent a second coronation ceremony under the patronage of Emperor Ashoka.
- Both Buddhism and a branch of the Sri Maha Bodhi were brought to Sri Lanka during his reign.
- Thuparamaya Dageba in Anuradhapura was built under his direction.
- The formal boundaries of Anuradhapura city were established during his rule.

5.3 King Dutugemunu

King Dutugemunu was a capable and decisive ruler. His father was King Kavantissa and his mother was the celebrated Queen Vihara Maha Devi. He had one brother named Tissa. The royal family resided in the Magama kingdom, which covered the southern and southeastern regions of Sri Lanka — a territory known in those times as Ruhunu Rata.

From a young age, Prince Dutugemunu recognized the potential of Anuradhapura and resolved that when the time came, he would rule it and develop it further.

5.3.1.King Elara

Before Dutugemunu came to power, Anuradhapura was governed by a king named Elara, who had come from the Chola region of South India. Elara collected revenues from both agriculture and trade through the Mathota harbour on the western coast near Anuradhapura. Despite being a foreign ruler, he was known for his sense of justice. On one occasion, when his own chariot accidentally damaged a Buddhist pagoda, he took immediate steps to have it repaired — a story preserved in the Mahawamsa.

King Kavantissa, recognizing his son's ambitions, began preparing by building up a strong military force and increasing food production. He also sent Prince Dutugemunu's brother, Prince Tissa, to Digamadulla — present day Ampara — as part of this broader strategy. Eventually, Prince Dutugemunu and King Elara met in direct combat at Vijithapura. Elara's forty four year reign came to an end with his defeat.

Following his victory, King Dutugemunu began construction of the Ruwanweli Seya — referred to in historical sources as Maha Tupa, and in Pali texts as Rathnamali. It is believed that bodily relics of the Lord Buddha, originally housed in a dageba at Ramagama in India, were enshrined within it. The stupa originally stood at a height of 300 feet with a base diameter of 298 feet. The king passed away before its completion, and the work was finished by his brother King Saddhatissa. Historical records credit King Dutugemunu with constructing ninety nine dagebas and religious establishments in total.

King Dutugemunu was supported in battle by ten exceptionally skilled commanders — Nandimithra, Suranimala, Mahasona, Gotayimbara, Theraputtabhaya, Bharana, Velusumana, Kanchadeva, Pussadeva, and Labhiya Vasabha. After the king's victory, these men became celebrated throughout the land as the Ten Great Giants, or Dasa Maha Yodhayo. The king's battle elephant, Kandula, was also a renowned figure in these military campaigns.

Among the structures built by King Dutugemunu were Miriswetiya, Ruwanweliseya, and Lowamahapaya. He also demonstrated magnanimity toward his defeated rival — he instructed his subjects to pay their respects whenever they passed by King Elara's burial site.

Though the king was widely known as Dutugemunu, his given name was Gamini Abhaya. The name Dutugemunu was adopted after he became king. The word "Dutu" derives from the Sanskrit "Drushtha," meaning intelligent.

Important Points:

- King Dutugemunu unified the country under one rule.
- He came from the Magama region in the south.
- His parents and brother provided crucial support in his campaign.
- Ten gifted military commanders assisted him in uniting the kingdom.
- Mirisawetiya, Ruwanweliseya, and Lowamahapaya were among the structures he built.
- King Elara, who preceded him, was a fair and just ruler who governed Anuradhapura for forty four years.

5.4 King Valagamba

King Valagamba was another distinguished ruler of Sri Lanka. His father was King Saddhatissa, though historical sources do not record who his mother was. He had three brothers — Thulattana, Lajjatissa, and Naga. His brother Naga later became king and ruled under the name Kallatanaga. Queen Somadevi was his wife.

His reign was not without difficulty. He faced an invasion by forces from South India as well as opposition from a Brahmin named Tissa who challenged his authority. Nevertheless, through wisdom and bravery, the king overcame each of these threats.

King Valagamba commissioned the construction of Abhayagiri Stupa in Anuradhapura. After its completion, he offered both the stupa and its surrounding temple to a monk named Kupikkala Tissa Thero, who had stood by the king during his most difficult times. The Abhayagiri temple later grew into a prominent international center of Buddhist learning.

5.4.1. Writing Down the Thripitaka

Perhaps the most historically significant event of King Valagamba's reign was the decision to commit the Buddhist teachings to written form. Until this time, the Thripitaka — the three collections of Buddhist doctrine as preached by the Lord Buddha — had been preserved entirely through oral tradition, with monks memorizing and reciting the texts across generations.

During a period when the king was in hiding in the forest, a severe famine known as Beminitiyasaya — caused by years without adequate rainfall — swept the country. A number of monks who had memorized the Thripitaka perished during this famine. Recognizing the danger of relying solely on oral transmission, the king arranged for the teachings to be written down for the first time. This was accomplished at Aluviharaya, a temple in Mathale. The transformation of the oral tradition into written scripture was a profound contribution not only to Sri Lanka but to Buddhists throughout the entire world.

The king also donated caves to monks and constructed educational establishments within temples to support monastic learning. He ordered the construction of a stupa named Somaramaya in honor of the place where Queen Soma Devi had courageously confronted the South Indian invaders. Queen Soma Devi herself was a woman of exceptional bravery — when the king faced invasion, she stepped forward to protect him without hesitation. Though she was captured and taken to South India, the king eventually defeated his enemies and brought her back to Sri Lanka, restoring her to her rightful place as his queen.

Important Points:

- King Saddhatissa was the father of King Valagamba.
- His reign was marked by challenges from foreign invaders.
- Queen Soma Devi displayed remarkable courage throughout these trials.
- The writing down of the Thripitaka and the construction of Abhayagiri Stupa stand as his greatest contributions to the nation.

5.5 King Vasabha

Little is known about King Vasabha's parentage — historical records contain no information about his mother or father. He spent his early years living with his uncle, who served as the country's military commander. King Vasabha came from a family lineage known as Lambakarna, whose members had traditionally managed the documentary affairs of the kingdom. Several distinguished kings from the Lambakarna line ruled Sri Lanka, with Vasabha being the first to do so as the founder of the Lambakarna dynasty.

His reign is particularly remembered for its extraordinary contribution to irrigation and water management. He was the first king to undertake the construction of eleven large reservoirs, along

with twelve canals designed to carry water from these tanks to agricultural fields. Among the most notable of these was the Elahera canal, which transported water across a distance of thirty miles.

Several of the tanks he constructed have been identified. The tank then known as Mayenthi is today called Mahawilachchiya Wewa. Manaketi is now known as Manankattiya Wewa, and Wathamangana Wewa has since been renamed Nochchipothana Wewa. All of these reservoirs are located within the Anuradhapura district.

King Vasabha also introduced underground pipe systems to carry water to bathing ponds, replacing the previous method of using open surface canals. To make administration more efficient, he divided the country into regional units and assigned officials to oversee each area. One such official, a minister named Isigiriya, was appointed to the present day Jaffna region. A record of this appointment, along with a note that minister Isigiriya constructed a temple in the area, was inscribed on a golden plate discovered at a site called Vallipuram in Jaffna — and is therefore known as the Vallipuram golden plate.

The king invested considerably in strengthening and beautifying Anuradhapura city. He arranged for a protective wall to be constructed around its perimeter — the ruins of which can still be seen in Anuradhapura today. Decorative ponds were added to the city, supplied with water from the tanks, and officials were instructed to keep swans in them.

His contribution to Buddhism was equally significant. He had a Vatadage — a circular protective structure — built around Thuparamaya Dageba, and constructed a chapter house within the Isurumuniya temple, offering both to the monks. He also built stupas at Sithulpawwa temple in Tissamaharama and undertook renovation work at temples across the country.

To fund these public works, King Vasabha introduced a taxation system. Those who drew water from the public tanks were required to pay a usage fee, and the revenue collected was directed toward the maintenance and repair of those same tanks. He ruled for forty four years, leaving behind a legacy defined by practical wisdom, careful governance, and genuine dedication to his people.

Important Points:

- King Vasabha was the founding ruler of the Lambakarna dynasty.
- He made an outstanding contribution to the country's irrigation, constructing eleven large reservoirs.
- The Vallipuram golden plate was produced during his reign.
- He introduced taxation and administrative divisions to improve governance across the kingdom.

5.6 King Mahasen

King Mahasen was one of the most celebrated rulers in Sri Lanka's history. His father was King Gotabhaya and he had a brother named Jettatissa. Historical records make no mention of his mother.

His reign is most strongly associated with the expansion and development of Sri Lanka's irrigation network. He constructed sixteen reservoirs and one major canal. Among the largest was Minneriya tank — known in ancient times as Minihira Wewa — whose bund stretches for one and a quarter miles and covers an area of 4,670 acres. Another tank he built, then called Wallurawapi, is today known as Hurulu Wewa. He also constructed Kanadara Wewa in Mihintale, which was originally called Khanu Wewa.

Beyond irrigation, King Mahasen was a dedicated patron of Buddhism. He built several temples, the most impressive being Jethawanaramaya in Anuradhapura. It is believed that the belt relic of the Lord Buddha is enshrined within the Jethawana Dageba he constructed. Other religious establishments built during his reign include Minneriya Viharaya, Gokanna Viharaya, Ekapilla Viharaya, and Dasengala Viharaya. He also carried out renovation work on existing temples across the country and regularly provided robes to monks. He governed the country for twenty seven years.

The depth of gratitude felt by his subjects was so great that they came to regard him as a divine figure. Because he built reservoirs of almost oceanic scale, he was venerated as a god — a tradition that continues to this day. He is worshipped under the name Minneri Deviyo, the God of Minneriya, and shrines dedicated to him can still be found in the Polonnaruwa region.

The Jethawana Stupa, his most towering architectural achievement, originally stood at a height of 400 feet with a base diameter of 370 feet. It was the largest stupa in Sri Lanka and the largest brick structure in the world at the time of its construction. Like the Abhayagiri complex, the Jethawana temple was surrounded by numerous monastery buildings.

Important Points:

- King Mahasen made an exceptional contribution to agriculture and irrigation in Sri Lanka.
- Minneriya tank, one of his greatest works, has a bund measuring one and a quarter miles in length and was once known as Minihira Wewa.
- The Jethawana Stupa in Anuradhapura, built by King Mahasen, was the tallest brick structure in Asia.
- King Mahasen continues to be worshipped as the God of Minneriya to this day.

5.7 King Dhathusena

King Dhathusena's father was a man named Datanama, and he had a younger brother called Salathisbo. Before Dhathusena came to power, six South Indian invaders — among them Pandu, Parinda, and Khudda Parinda — had seized control of Anuradhapura. King Dhathusena successfully drove out these invaders and liberated the country. He belonged to the royal lineage known as the Maurya dynasty.

The most celebrated aspect of King Dhathusena's legacy is his contribution to irrigation. Historical texts record that he oversaw the construction of eighteen large tanks and eighteen smaller ones. His greatest engineering achievement was Kala Wewa in Anuradhapura, which continues to serve the people of that region to this day. He also constructed the canal known as Yodha Ela — also called Jaya Ganga — which connects Kala Wewa with Tisa Wewa in Anuradhapura. This canal stretches fifty four miles in length and maintains a gradient of six inches per mile — a remarkable feat of ancient engineering.

King Dhathusena was equally dedicated to the advancement of Buddhism within the country. He constructed several new temples and restored those that had fallen into disrepair. The Mahawamsa records that he built eighteen temples in total. He consistently attended to the needs of the monastic community and reconstructed the Maha Pali alms hall — a large dining establishment to which monks came to receive their daily meals.

He ruled for eighteen years and had two sons named Kashyapa and Mugalan, as well as a daughter. Given that the majority of the population depended on agriculture for their livelihood, the king directed much of his energy toward strengthening the country's irrigation capacity. His devoted service to both the monastic community and the ordinary people of Sri Lanka stands as an enduring model of enlightened leadership.

Important Points:

- King Dhathusena belonged to the Maurya royal dynasty.
- His irrigation works included Kala Wewa and the Yodha Ela canal, in addition to eighteen large and eighteen small tanks.
- He made a substantial contribution to the growth and preservation of Buddhism throughout the country.

The kings described in this chapter each left a profound mark on Sri Lanka's history. Whether through constructing cities, bringing Buddhism to the island, uniting the country, or building reservoirs that fed entire populations, these rulers demonstrated that courageous and wise leadership can shape a nation for generations to come. Their stories serve as an inspiration for every citizen to contribute meaningfully to their own society.